



RV OWNERS Maintenance Guide

**The Complete Guide to Protecting, Maintaining &
Extending the Life of Your RV - Everything
Dealers Forget to Mention**

12 Chapters • Step-by-Step Checklists • Seasonal Schedules • Pro Insider Tips

Pre-Trip Inspection	Water & Plumbing Secrets	Winterizing Step-by-Step
Engine & Mechanical	Electrical & Solar Guide	Roof & Slide-Out Repairs

CHAPTER

Table of Contents

Ch. 1	Introduction - Why Every RV Owner Needs This Guide	3
Ch. 2	Pre-Trip Inspection - The 20-Minute Ritual That Saves Thousands	5
Ch. 3	Engine & Drivetrain - Keep Your RV Moving Mile After Mile	7
Ch. 4	Roof & Exterior - The Biggest Mistake RV Owners Make	9
Ch. 5	Water System & Plumbing - What's Hiding in Your Pipes	11
Ch. 6	Electrical Systems & Solar - Power Without the Panic	13
Ch. 7	Slide-Outs & Awnings - The Parts Dealers Never Maintain	15
Ch. 8	Seals, Caulking & Leak Prevention - Stop Water Damage Before It Starts	17
Ch. 9	Tires & Brakes - The Safety Checks That Can Save Your Life	19
Ch. 10	Winterizing Your RV - The Complete Cold-Weather Protocol	21
Ch. 11	Seasonal Maintenance Calendar - Your Year-Round Master Plan	23
Ch. 12	Emergency Breakout Kit - What Every RV Must Carry	25
BONUS	Costly RV Mistakes First-Time Owners Make	27

★ **BONUS INSIDE:** The Dealer's Maintenance Checklist They Never Give You - Use it to catch problems before they cost you \$5,000+

INTRODUCTION

Why Every RV Owner Needs This Guide

Owning an RV is one of the greatest freedoms in modern life - the open road, the flexibility to go anywhere, and the comfort of home wherever you park. But that freedom comes with real responsibility. Unlike a standard vehicle or a stationary home, an RV is both of those things at once: a moving mechanical system and a living space, each with its own complex maintenance demands. Most first-time RV owners have no idea what they've taken on until something goes wrong - and by then, the repair bill can easily run into the thousands.

The hard truth is that dealers rarely walk new owners through proper maintenance. Manufacturers provide thin manuals that cover the basics but skip the real insider knowledge that comes from years of experience on the road. As a result, avoidable problems - burst water lines from improper winterizing, roof leaks from missed sealant checks, blown tires from neglected pressure monitoring - become shockingly common. This guide exists to close that gap. It was built by compiling the hard-won wisdom of experienced RVers, mechanics, and technicians into a single, no-nonsense resource that tells you exactly what to do, when to do it, and what to watch for before it costs you.

Whether you're a first-time buyer still learning the difference between your gray tank and your black tank, or a seasoned camper who wants a more systematic approach to upkeep, this guide is built for you. It covers every major system in your RV - engine and drivetrain, roof and exterior, water and plumbing, electrical and solar, tires and brakes, slide-outs, and more - with step-by-step checklists, seasonal schedules, and clear explanations of what matters most. Follow it consistently and you won't just avoid disasters - you'll extend the life of your RV by years and protect an investment that can easily be worth \$50,000 to \$500,000.

★ **PRO TIP:** Print the seasonal checklists at the end of this guide and keep them in your RV. A quick reference you can actually reach for is worth ten guides left on your laptop at home.

How to Use This Guide

Each chapter focuses on one major system or topic and is structured the same way: a brief overview explaining why the topic matters, followed by the specific tasks you need to perform and how often. Pro tips, warnings, and money-saving notes are called out in highlighted boxes so they're impossible to miss.

SECTION	WHAT YOU'LL LEARN
Chapters 2–11	Core RV systems: inspection, engine, roof, water, electrical, slide-outs, seals, tires, winterizing, calendar
Chapter 12	Emergency Kit - what to carry in your RV at all times for roadside and campsite emergencies
Bonus Chapter	The most expensive mistakes first-time RV owners make - and exactly how to avoid them

What Makes an RV Different From a Car or a House

Your RV faces challenges that neither a car nor a house has to deal with on their own. It vibrates at highway speed for hours at a time - loosening bolts, stressing seals, and fatiguing every joint. It sits parked in sun, rain, snow, and UV exposure for months at a stretch. It carries a fresh water system, a gray water system, a black water system, an LP gas system, a 12V DC system, and a 120V AC system - all in the same vehicle. Understanding this complexity is the first step to maintaining it correctly.

- An RV roof seal can fail in as little as 6 months of UV exposure - leading to water damage that rots framing.
- RV tires degrade from age and UV exposure even when they look perfect - a 7-year-old tire can blow without warning.
- Propane, electrical, and water systems all intersect - a leak in one can damage or endanger the others.
- Black tank buildup, clogged sensors, and drain pyramid blocks are almost entirely preventable with the right habits.
- Generator neglect is the #1 cause of costly RV generator replacement - and it only takes 2 hours a month to prevent.

★ PRO TIP: Think of your RV as a living system, not a static object. It needs regular attention even when you're not using it. A 30-minute monthly walkthrough during storage can prevent a \$10,000 surprise in the spring.

CHAPTER 1

Pre-Trip Inspection The 20-Minute Ritual That Saves Thousands

Most RV owners skip the pre-trip inspection - and that's exactly why so many end up stranded on the highway with a blown tire, a dead battery, or a water leak that soaked their mattress. This 20-minute ritual costs nothing and can save you thousands in emergency repairs and towing fees.

★ **PRO TIP:** Do this inspection the night **BEFORE** your trip, not the morning of - so you have time to fix anything you find.

Exterior Walk-Around Checklist

ITEM	DONE
Check all tires for proper inflation and visible damage/cracking	■
Inspect wheel lug nuts - look for rust staining or looseness	■
Examine all exterior seams and seals for cracks or gaps	■
Test all exterior lights: headlights, brake lights, turn signals	■
Verify slide-outs are fully retracted and latched	■
Check roof vents and antenna are down/secured	■
Inspect hitch, safety chains, and trailer brake connection	■
Verify all cargo bay doors are locked and secure	■
Look under the RV for fresh fluid drips or wet spots	■
Check that sewer hose and hookup gear are stowed and latched	■

Interior Checks

ITEM	DONE
Test propane detector and carbon monoxide alarm	■
Check fire extinguisher pressure gauge (needle in green)	■
Verify refrigerator is switched to 12V or propane travel mode	■
Turn off water heater and water pump before travel	■
Secure all cabinet doors and loose items	■
Check brake fluid, engine oil, and coolant levels (motorhomes)	■

Confirm all roof vents are closed and latched	■
Verify emergency exit hatches are closed and sealed	■

■ **WARNING: NEVER** travel with the water heater on propane - the pilot light is an explosion risk at fuel stations. Switch to electric only when parked with hookups.

CHAPTER 1 (CONTINUED)

Pre-Trip: Systems & Safety Verification

Mechanical Systems Verification

Beyond the basic walkaround, a complete pre-trip includes checking the mechanical systems that can fail silently between trips - especially if the RV has been sitting for more than a few weeks.

SYSTEM	CHECK	FREQUENCY
Engine Oil	Check dipstick level and color	Every trip
Coolant	Check overflow reservoir level	Every trip
Brake Fluid	Check reservoir level	Every trip
Transmission Fluid	Check level when warm	Monthly
Generator Oil	Check dipstick level	Every 100 hours
LP Gas	Check tank gauge	Every trip
House Batteries	Check voltage (12.6V+ = good)	Every trip
Fresh Water Tank	Check level or fill to desired	Every trip

Hitch & Towing Safety (Towables)

For fifth-wheels and travel trailers, the hitch connection is your most critical safety system. A failed hitch can result in a fully separated trailer on the highway - a catastrophic and potentially fatal event.

ITEM	DONE
Kingpin/ball fully seated and hitch locked - perform tug test before driving	■
Weight distribution bars installed and tensioned correctly	■
Sway bar connected and adjusted (if applicable)	■
Safety chains crossed and connected - not dragging	■
7-pin or 4-pin connector fully inserted and lights tested	■
Trailer brake controller tested - apply brakes gently at 5 MPH to verify	■
Emergency breakaway cable connected to tow vehicle	■
Mirrors adjusted to see full trailer width on both sides	■

The 10-Minute Stop Protocol

For trips over 100 miles, stop after the first 30–50 miles and do a quick check. This catches problems that only appear once the vehicle is in motion and warmed up.

- Walk around and check all tires for heat, bulging, or pressure loss
- Check that hitch is still fully locked and chains are clear of the road
- Look under the tow vehicle and trailer for fluid drips
- Open one cargo bay and verify nothing has shifted or opened
- Check your trailer brake controller is reading correctly

★ PRO TIP: Download a tire pressure monitoring app and check your readings at your first fuel stop. Tires heat up in the first hour of driving - a tire that reads fine cold can be under-inflated once hot.

CHAPTER 2

Engine & Drivetrain Keep Your RV Moving Mile After Mile

For Class A and Class C motorhomes, the engine is your biggest mechanical investment. Neglect it and you're looking at repair bills that easily exceed \$8,000–\$15,000. Diesels and gas engines have different needs - know which one you have and maintain accordingly.

Essential Fluid Checks

FLUID	CHECK INTERVAL	REPLACE WHEN
Engine Oil	Every 3,000 mi (gas) / 5,000–7,500 mi (diesel)	Dark/dirty on dipstick
Coolant	Every 6 months	Every 2 years / 30,000 mi
Transmission Fluid	Every 30,000 mi	Dark red or burnt smell
Brake Fluid	Every 12 months	Brown or moisture present
Power Steering Fluid	Every 12 months	Brown or foamy
Differential Oil	Every 30,000 mi	Metal flakes present
Transfer Case Fluid	Every 30,000 mi	Dark or contaminated

★ **MONEY SAVER:** A \$12 fuel stabilizer added before storage can prevent a \$400+ carburetor rebuild. Add it every time you store your RV for more than 30 days.

Generator Maintenance

Your RV generator needs to run at least 2 hours per month under load (with AC on) to keep seals lubricated and fuel lines clear. Change generator oil every 100 hours of use or annually - whichever comes first. Always use the manufacturer-specified oil weight.

Belt & Hose Inspection

- Serpentine belt: Check for cracks, fraying, or glazing - replace every 60,000–80,000 miles
- Radiator hoses: Squeeze when cold - soft/spongy means replacement needed
- Coolant hoses: Look for white mineral deposits around clamp areas (sign of slow leak)
- Air filter: Inspect every 15,000 miles - replace if gray or clogged

CHAPTER 2 (CONTINUED)

Engine & Drivetrain: Diesel vs. Gas & Chassis Care

Diesel vs. Gas: Key Differences

FACTOR	GAS ENGINE	DIESEL ENGINE
Oil change interval	3,000–5,000 miles	5,000–15,000 miles
Fuel system care	Fuel stabilizer in storage	Algaecide in diesel tanks
Cold weather	Easier cold starts	Needs glow plugs / block heater
DEF (Diesel Exhaust Fluid)	Not applicable	Check level every 3,000 miles
Typical lifespan	150,000–200,000 miles	300,000–500,000 miles
Turbo care	Not typically turbocharged	Let idle 5 min before shutdown

Chassis & Suspension

The chassis on a Class A motorhome is often shared with a commercial truck platform (Freightliner, Ford F-53, Spartan). These chassis have their own maintenance schedules separate from the house systems.

ITEM	DONE
Grease all chassis lube points every 6,000 miles (ask your shop to do this)	☐
Inspect leaf springs or air bag suspension for damage or leaks	☐
Check steering components: tie rods, drag links, ball joints annually	☐
Inspect exhaust system for leaks, loose hangers, or corrosion	☐
Verify front end alignment annually - RV weight causes rapid tire wear when out of spec	☐
Check shock absorbers for leaking - grab and push - no rebound = replace	☐

■ **WARNING:** If your motorhome pulls to one side, don't just align it - have the chassis inspected first. Bent frame components from a previous impact can make alignment impossible to hold.

Annual Engine Service Checklist

ITEM	DONE
Oil and filter change with correct weight oil for your engine	☐
Fuel filter replacement (gas: annually; diesel: every 15,000–30,000 miles)	☐

Spark plugs inspected or replaced (gas engines every 30,000 miles)	■
Battery load test - not just a voltage check	■
Coolant system pressure test to check for slow leaks	■
Full generator service: oil, air filter, spark plugs (gas gen) or fuel filter (diesel gen)	■
Inspect all engine mounts for cracking or collapse	■

CHAPTER 3

Roof & Exterior The Biggest Mistake RV Owners Make

Water damage is the #1 cause of total-loss RV write-offs. And here's the dirty secret: 90% of all water damage starts at the roof - from a tiny crack in the sealant that most owners never notice until it's already rotting the walls and subfloor. A \$15 tube of lap sealant applied twice a year can save you from a \$20,000 repair.

■ **WARNING:** If you see any soft spots on your floor near the walls, stained ceiling panels, or bubbling wallpaper - you already have water intrusion. Act immediately before it spreads to structural wood.

Roof Types & Care Requirements

ROOF TYPE	CLEAN WITH	CONDITION WITH	INSPECT EVERY
EPDM Rubber	Mild dish soap + water	303 Protectant	90 days
TPO / Filon	TPO cleaner	UV protectant spray	90 days
Aluminum	Oxidation remover	Wax or polish	6 months
Fiberglass	Non-abrasive cleaner	RV fiberglass wax	6 months

The Critical Sealing Points

Every penetration on your roof is a potential leak point. Inspect and reseal all of the following with self-leveling lap sealant every spring and fall:

- AC unit mounting base and all four corners
- Roof vents - both around the base and under the lid
- TV antenna and satellite dish mounts
- All seams where roof meets sidewalls (especially front and rear caps)
- Any screws visible on the roof surface
- Skylight frames and rain gutters

★ **PRO TIP:** Dicor Self-Leveling Lap Sealant is the industry gold standard. Never use silicone on rubber roofs - it causes irreversible damage.

CHAPTER 3 (CONTINUED)

Roof & Exterior: Sidewalls, Caulking & Cleaning

Sidewall & Exterior Seam Inspection

The roof gets most of the attention, but sidewall seams and corner moldings are equally important. UV exposure causes sealant to shrink, crack, and pull away from joints - creating entry points for water that can run down inside the wall cavity for months before you notice.

ITEM	DONE
Inspect all horizontal and vertical exterior seams with caulk - probe with fingernail for soft spots	■
Check front and rear cap seams (junction of fiberglass cap and sidewall)	■
Inspect all slide-out seams on exterior - both above and below	■
Look for any exterior screws that have lost their seal (rust streaks are the telltale sign)	■
Inspect window frames and door frames for gap or peeling sealant	■
Check underbelly material for tears, sagging, or moisture intrusion	■
Inspect any basement compartment door frames for seal degradation	■

Exterior Washing & Waxing Protocol

SURFACE	PRODUCT	FREQUENCY
Fiberglass exterior	RV wash + non-abrasive wax	Every 3–4 months
Aluminum exterior	Aluminum cleaner + polish	Every 6 months
Rubber roof	Rubber roof cleaner only	Every 3 months
Slide-out toppers	Awning cleaner + fabric protector	Twice per season
Chrome/stainless trim	Metal polish	Annually
Undercarriage	Pressure wash + rust inhibitor spray	Annually

★ **PRO TIP:** Wax your fiberglass RV every spring before travel season. A good wax coat reduces UV damage, makes cleaning easier, and keeps oxidation from dulling the finish. Neglected fiberglass oxidizes permanently and requires expensive compound polishing to restore.

Skylight & Vent Lid Maintenance

- Inspect acrylic skylight domes annually for yellowing, hazing, or micro-cracks - replace before they shatter

- Check vent lid hinges and spring tension - a vent that blows open at highway speed can crack the frame
- Apply 303 Aerospace Protectant to plastic vent lids to slow UV degradation
- Inspect the vent fan blades and screen mesh - clean annually to prevent blockage

CHAPTER 4

Water System & Plumbing What's Hiding in Your Pipes

Your RV's water system is a complex network of fresh water, gray water, and black water - and each tank has its own maintenance needs. Ignore them and you're dealing with foul odors, clogged sensors, and bacteria in your drinking water. Here's everything you need to know.

Sanitizing the Fresh Water System

Do this every spring when you de-winterize, after any extended storage, and whenever the water smells or tastes off:

Step 1	Mix 1/4 cup of household bleach per 15 gallons of tank capacity
Step 2	Fill the fresh water tank with the bleach/water mixture
Step 3	Run each faucet (hot and cold) until you smell bleach - then stop
Step 4	Let it sit for 4–12 hours (overnight is ideal)
Step 5	Drain completely and refill with fresh water
Step 6	Run all faucets until bleach smell is gone - repeat fill/drain if needed

Black & Gray Tank Maintenance

- Always dump black tank FIRST, then gray - the gray water rinses the sewer hose
- Use RV-specific tank treatments (enzyme-based is best for sensor accuracy)
- Never leave tanks connected to sewer with valves open - this dries out the tank and causes pyramid buildup
- Flush black tank with a tank rinser wand after every dump - this prevents solid buildup
- Clean sensors quarterly with Ice + Dawn dish soap method: fill 1/3, add ice + 1 cup Dawn, drive around

■ **WARNING: NEVER use household toilet paper in your RV. Use RV-safe TP or test yours - if it doesn't dissolve in 30 seconds in a jar of water, it will clog your black tank.**

CHAPTER 4 (CONTINUED)

Water System: Water Heater, Filters & Pump Care

Water Heater Maintenance

Your RV water heater (typically 6 or 10 gallon) requires annual service to prevent sediment buildup, anode rod corrosion, and burner failure. Most are Suburban or Atwood units with similar service needs.

ITEM	DONE
Drain and flush water heater tank annually - remove sediment that reduces efficiency	■
Inspect anode rod (if applicable) - replace when less than 50% remaining	■
Clean burner tube with compressed air - spider webs block gas flow and cause ignition failure	■
Test pressure relief valve annually - lift lever briefly to verify it opens and reseats	■
Check gas supply line connection for leaks with soapy water (bubbles = leak)	■
Inspect electrical heating element (dual-source units) for corrosion or failure	■

Water Filtration & Pump

COMPONENT	TASK	INTERVAL
Inline water filter	Replace filter cartridge	Every 3–6 months
Water pump strainer	Clean mesh screen	Every 6 months
Water pump	Listen for pulsing (pre-pressure loss)	Every trip
Water pump fittings	Inspect for moisture/weeping	Seasonally
Pressure regulator	Test inlet pressure (max 60 PSI)	At every hookup
Drinking water filter	Replace per manufacturer schedule	Varies

■ **WARNING:** A pulsing water pump when a faucet is open usually means a small leak somewhere in the system. Find and fix it early - a dripping fitting inside a wall cavity can cause catastrophic damage over a season.

Winterizing the Water System Preview

Full winterizing protocol is covered in Chapter 10. Key reminder: never skip antifreeze in the P-traps (sink drains and shower drains). A frozen P-trap can crack the trap fitting inside the wall - an expensive repair that's nearly impossible to reach without cutting into cabinetry.

CHAPTER 5

Electrical Systems & Solar Power Without the Panic

Your RV has two separate electrical systems: 12V DC (batteries) and 120V AC (shore power/generator). Understanding both - and keeping them healthy - means never waking up to a dead battery or a tripped breaker in the middle of the night.

Battery Health & Maintenance

BATTERY TYPE	DEPTH OF DISCHARGE	LIFESPAN	MAINTENANCE
Lead-Acid (Flooded)	Max 50%	2–5 years	Check water monthly
AGM	Max 50%	4–7 years	Sealed - no maintenance
Lithium (LiFePO4)	Down to 10–20%	10–15 years	BMS handles it - minimal
Gel Cell	Max 50%	3–6 years	No water, avoid high temps

★ INVEST IN THIS: Switching from 2x 100Ah lead-acid to 1x 100Ah Lithium actually gives you MORE usable power - lithium can discharge to 20% vs lead-acid's 50% limit.

Shore Power & Surge Protection

Always plug your RV through a surge protector/EMS (Electrical Management System). Campground power is notoriously dirty - low voltage, miswired pedestals, and power surges are extremely common and can destroy your converter, inverter, and appliances instantly. A quality EMS unit costs \$150–\$350 and can save \$2,000+ in appliance damage.

Solar System Care

- Clean solar panels monthly with water and soft cloth - dirt reduces output by up to 25%
- Check all wire connections for corrosion every 6 months - use dielectric grease
- Inspect roof mounts for cracks in sealant around each panel anchor
- If output drops significantly, test each panel individually with a multimeter
- Keep batteries at float voltage (13.6V) during storage to extend lifespan

CHAPTER 5 (CONTINUED)

Electrical: Converter, Inverter & 12V System

Converter & Inverter Explained

DEVICE	WHAT IT DOES	MAINTENANCE
Converter	Converts 120V AC shore power to 12V DC to charge batteries and power 12V circuits	Inspect fan vent for dust buildup annually
Inverter	Converts 12V DC battery power to 120V AC for appliances when off-grid	Check connections for corrosion; verify output with multimeter
Converter/Inverter combo	Does both - common in modern RVs	Same as above - check both functions annually

12V System Maintenance Checklist

ITEM	DONE
Check all battery terminals for corrosion - clean with baking soda + water, coat with dielectric grease	■
Test battery voltage at rest: 12.6V+ = fully charged; below 12.0V = needs immediate charging	■
Inspect all 12V wiring runs for chafing or pinching against metal edges	■
Test all 12V lights, fans, and control panels for proper operation	■
Check converter output voltage: should read 13.6V–14.4V when charging	■
Inspect battery disconnect switch for corrosion or looseness	■
Verify all ground connections are tight and corrosion-free	■

Generator Integration & Load Management

Your generator and shore power system share the same 120V bus in your RV. Overloading this system trips breakers and, over time, damages the transfer switch. Know your load limits.

APPLIANCE	TYPICAL DRAW	NOTES
Air Conditioner (13,500 BTU)	~1,500–1,800W	Startup surge 2x running draw
Electric Water Heater	~1,200W	Don't run simultaneously with AC
Microwave	~1,000–1,500W	High surge - use alone
Refrigerator (compressor)	~150–400W	Continuous - plan around this

Hair Dryer / Curling Iron	~1,000–1,875W	Avoid on small generators
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CHAPTER 6

Slide-Outs & Awnings The Parts Dealers Never Maintain for You

Slide-outs add valuable living space - but they're also one of the most expensive things to repair on an RV. A single slide motor replacement can cost \$500–\$1,500. Routine lubrication and seal maintenance keeps them running smoothly and watertight for years.

Slide-Out Maintenance Schedule

ITEM	DONE
Lubricate slide rails with dry PTFE spray (not WD-40 - attracts dirt)	■
Inspect and clean rubber seals - remove debris and condition with rubber protectant	■
Check slide topper (fabric awning over slide) for tears, pooling water, mold	■
Test slide travel in both directions - listen for grinding or hesitation	■
Inspect floor edge seal for gaps - this is where most slide water leaks occur	■
Verify mechanism bolts are tight - vibration loosens them over time	■
Check wiring harness running through slide for chafing or pinching	■
Lubricate manual override mechanism annually - verify it works	■

Awning Care & Operation

Your RV awning is designed for shade, not for rain. A common - and costly - mistake is leaving the awning out during storms. Wind + pooled water = torn fabric or bent arms in minutes.

- Always retract your awning when leaving your site - wind can appear suddenly
- Clean fabric with awning cleaner + soft brush twice per season (or when visibly dirty)
- Dry completely before rolling up to prevent mold and mildew
- Lubricate arm pivot points and tension knob with white lithium grease annually
- Adjust pitch slightly downward so rainwater runs off before it pools
- Inspect for UV degradation - bubbling or brittleness means replacement soon

★ **PRO TIP:** If your awning won't retract fully, the spring tension may need adjustment. Most adjustments can be made with a 9/16 socket in under 5 minutes - watch a YouTube tutorial first.

CHAPTER 6 (CONTINUED)

Slide-Outs & Awnings: Troubleshooting & Storage

Slide-Out Troubleshooting Guide

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Slide moves slowly	Dry or dirty slide rails	Clean + lubricate with PTFE spray
Slide stops mid-travel	Low battery voltage	Charge batteries; check converter
Grinding noise	Debris in rail or worn gear	Inspect and clean; call service if grinding continues
Water intrusion at slide edge	Failed floor edge seal or damaged wiper seal	Replace slide seals - DIY or dealer
Slide won't move at all	Blown fuse, failed switch, or motor failure	Check fuse first; then test switch; then motor
Uneven travel (one side lags)	Out of sync motors or obstruction	Do not force - call service

Winter Storage & Slide-Out Protocol

During storage, your slide-outs should generally be fully retracted. Leaving them extended creates additional stress on seals and can allow snow and ice buildup to damage the topper fabric and seal edges.

ITEM	DONE
Retract all slides fully before storage - verify latched flush with body	■
Inspect all slide seals and apply rubber conditioner to prevent winter cracking	■
Clean slide topper fabric and ensure fully dry before retraction	■
Apply PTFE lubricant to all rails before retraction for spring	■
Place moisture absorber inside RV - slide seals can allow humidity ingress	■

Window Awnings & Patio Accessories

- Window awnings: inspect fabric for UV cracking and clean twice per season
- Patio mat: rinse and dry before storing - wet mats cause mold and odors
- Outdoor furniture: store in compartments or under an RV storage cover
- Exterior entertainment center: cover or remove screen during storage

CHAPTER 7

Seals, Caulking & Leak Prevention Stop Water Damage Before It Starts

Water is the silent destroyer of RVs. Most structural damage - rotted floor framing, delaminated walls, black mold behind panels - starts with a seal failure so small you could cover it with a fingertip. A proactive sealing routine is the single highest-ROI maintenance task you can perform.

Sealant Types & Where to Use Them

SEALANT TYPE	USE ON	DO NOT USE ON
Dicor Self-Leveling Lap Sealant	EPDM rubber roofs - horizontal surfaces	Vertical surfaces, TPO roofs
Dicor Non-Sag Lap Sealant	Vertical surfaces, sidewall seams	Do not use as substitute for self-leveling
EternaBond Tape	Emergency roof repairs, large seam gaps	Small detail work
Butyl Tape	Window and vent frames during replacement	Exposed finished areas
Self-Etching Primer + Sealant	Aluminum body seams	Rubber roof surfaces

Bi-Annual Sealing Checklist (Spring & Fall)

ITEM	DONE
Walk entire roof - probe all sealant with fingernail for cracks or lift	■
Re-apply lap sealant over any cracked, discolored, or lifting areas	■
Inspect all sidewall horizontal seams - prod with fingernail for soft spots	■
Check all window and door frame perimeter seals - apply non-sag sealant where needed	■
Inspect junction of any rubber or metal trim and main body	■
Check underside of any slide room walls where they meet the main body	■
Verify all hitch receiver and tow package mounting bolts are sealed	■

■ **WARNING:** Before re-sealing, remove all old sealant completely. Applying new sealant over old cracked sealant just delays the problem - water will migrate under the new layer and follow the old cracks.

CHAPTER 7 (CONTINUED)

Seals & Caulking: Detecting & Repairing Active Leaks

How to Find a Leak - The Systematic Method

Finding the source of a roof or sidewall leak is notoriously difficult because water travels. The stain you see inside may be 3 feet from where the water is actually entering. Use this method:

Step 1	On a dry day, have a helper inside while you run a hose across the roof - starting at the REAR and working forward
Step 2	Soak each section for 60 seconds while the helper watches for new drips
Step 3	When drips appear, back up one section - the entry is usually just uphill of where water shows
Step 4	Mark the area with tape and inspect when dry - probe all sealant within 6 inches of the mark
Step 5	Clean, dry, and reseal - then re-test before closing up

Delamination: What It Is and What to Do

Delamination occurs when the outer fiberglass or aluminum skin separates from the foam insulation core inside the wall panel. It looks like bubbling, rippling, or waves in the sidewall exterior. This is almost always caused by water intrusion that has been active for months.

- Delamination is NOT a cosmetic issue - it means structural failure of the wall panel is in progress
- Minor delamination can sometimes be injected with adhesive and clamped - catch it early
- Major delamination requires full wall panel replacement - costs \$2,000–\$8,000+
- Prevention: inspect sidewalls for any rippling every 6 months, especially after travel

CHAPTER 8

Tires & Brakes The Safety Checks That Can Save Your Life

Blowouts are the #1 cause of RV accidents on the highway. Yet most RV owners check tire pressure less than once a year. Combined with proper brake maintenance, these two systems can literally save your life - and your entire rig.

■ **WARNING:** RV tires age out **BEFORE** they wear out. Never use a tire older than 6 years regardless of tread depth. UV breaks down rubber internally - you can't see the danger until it blows.

Tire Safety Non-Negotiables

TIRE CHECK	HOW OFTEN	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Tire pressure	Before every trip	Match cold PSI on placard (not max on sidewall)
Tread depth	Monthly	Replace below 4/32" depth
Sidewall inspection	Monthly	Cracks, bulges, or UV checking
Date code (DOT)	At purchase + annually	4-digit code: week+year (e.g. 1820 = 18th week 2020)
Wheel torque	Every 10,000 mi	Re-torque to spec after first 50 miles of new tires

Brake System Maintenance

- Inspect brake pads and rotors every 12,000 miles or annually
- Test trailer brake controller calibration before each trip
- Flush brake fluid every 2 years - moisture causes dangerous fade under heavy braking
- Check brake wiring connections and ground straps for corrosion
- Have a brake job done by an RV-specialist shop - regular mechanics often miss RV-specific specs

★ **INVEST IN THIS:** A TPMS (Tire Pressure Monitoring System) for ~\$80-\$150 gives you real-time alerts if any tire loses pressure while driving - it's genuinely life-saving equipment.

CHAPTER 8 (CONTINUED)

Tires & Brakes: Leveling, Weight & Blowout Response

Understanding Tire Load Ratings

Every RV tire has a load rating - the maximum weight it can safely carry. Overloading tires is one of the leading causes of blowouts. Many RVers unknowingly exceed tire load ratings by carrying too much gear.

LOAD RANGE	PLY RATING	TYPICAL USE
D	8-ply equivalent	Lighter travel trailers and smaller RVs
E	10-ply equivalent	Most Class A, B, C motorhomes and larger trailers
F	12-ply equivalent	Heavy Class A diesel pushers and large 5th wheels
G	14-ply equivalent	Super C motorhomes and commercial-grade chassis

What to Do in a Tire Blowout

A tire blowout in an RV is a terrifying experience. The wrong instinct - hitting the brakes - can cause a jackknife or rollover. The right response is counter-intuitive but critical to know before it happens.

Step 1	DO NOT BRAKE HARD - grip the wheel firmly and maintain your line
Step 2	Gently accelerate slightly - this stabilizes the vehicle
Step 3	Gradually ease off the throttle and let the RV slow naturally
Step 4	Steer toward the shoulder slowly - signal and move over calmly
Step 5	Once safely off-road, come to a complete stop and engage hazard lights
Step 6	Call for roadside assistance - do not attempt to change a blown tire on the highway

CHAPTER 9

Winterizing Your RV The Complete Cold-Weather Protocol

Proper winterizing prevents the most expensive single repair in RV ownership: burst water lines and cracked tanks from freezing. Follow this protocol every fall before temperatures drop to 32°F.

Complete Winterizing Protocol

1	Drain and flush fresh water tank completely
2	Drain water heater (remove anode rod if applicable)
3	Drain all low-point drains (hot and cold lines)
4	Bypass water heater using bypass valve
5	Pump non-toxic RV antifreeze through all faucets until pink color appears
6	Don't forget: toilet, outdoor shower, ice maker, washer/dryer lines
7	Pour 1–2 cups antifreeze in each drain (sinks, shower, toilet)
8	Disconnect and remove batteries - store in a warm location on a trickle charger
9	Cover roof vents to prevent pest entry
10	Place mouse bait/deterrent inside (dryer sheets, peppermint, bait stations)
11	Remove all food, medications, and anything that can freeze or attract pests
12	Cover tires with UV-blocking covers to prevent dry rot during storage

■ **WARNING:** Use food-grade non-toxic RV antifreeze (pink) - never automotive antifreeze (green/orange). Automotive antifreeze is toxic and will contaminate your water system.

CHAPTER 9 (CONTINUED)

Winterizing: Storage Prep & Spring De-Winterizing

Exterior & Structural Storage Prep

ITEM	DONE
Wax exterior or apply UV protectant - UV damage continues even in winter	☐
Inspect and reseal all roof penetrations and sidewall seams before storage	☐
Apply slide-out seal conditioner to all rubber seals before retracting	☐
Cover tires with UV-rated tire covers - position to allow airflow underneath	☐
Apply tire dressing to all tires to slow dry rot	☐
Cover RV with a breathable RV cover if stored outdoors	☐
Prop refrigerator and freezer doors open to prevent mold growth	☐
Leave cabinet doors open throughout to allow airflow	☐
Place DampRid or silica gel packs in closets and storage areas	☐

Spring De-Winterizing Checklist

Coming out of winter storage isn't just removing antifreeze - it's a full systems check after months of dormancy.

ITEM	DONE
Remove tire covers and tire blocks - inspect tires for flat spots and check pressure	☐
Reconnect batteries and check charge level - charge if below 12.4V	☐
Remove bypass valve setting - reinstall anode rod in water heater	☐
Flush entire water system until all pink antifreeze is gone (run all faucets)	☐
Sanitize fresh water system with bleach solution (see Chapter 4)	☐
Test all propane appliances: furnace, stove, water heater, refrigerator	☐
Test all 12V systems: lights, fans, water pump, slides, awning	☐
Test all 120V systems: outlets, AC, microwave, entertainment	☐
Inspect roof and reseal any cracks visible after winter freeze-thaw cycles	☐
Run generator under load for 30 minutes and check for proper output	☐

★ **MONEY SAVER:** Spending 4 hours on proper winterizing can prevent \$3,000–\$15,000 in burst pipe and cracked tank repairs. It's the single best maintenance investment of the year.

CHAPTER 10

Seasonal Maintenance Calendar Your Year-Round Master Plan

Consistent maintenance is about timing, not just tasks. This calendar gives you a clear picture of what to do and when throughout the year - from de-winterizing in spring to sealing up for winter storage.

Year-Round Maintenance Calendar

SPRING (De-Winterize)	• Sanitize water system - flush all antifreeze • Inspect roof seals - reseal anything cracked • Check tire dates and pressure • Test all appliances - gas, electric, 12V, 120V • Recharge or reinstall batteries • Lubricate slide rails, door hinges, and locks • Wash and wax exterior • Inspect and condition all rubber seals
SUMMER (Active Use)	• Pre-trip inspection before every trip • Check AC filter monthly - clean if dirty • Monitor tire pressure weekly • Clean awning after each trip • Inspect slide-out seals after each extension • Check solar panel output and clean panels monthly • Dump and flush black tank after every trip • Run generator under load every 30 days
FALL (Winterize)	• Full winterize protocol (see Chapter 9) • Deep-clean both tanks - enzyme treatment • Treat generator fuel with stabilizer • Wax exterior and apply UV protectant • Inspect and reseal all roof and sidewall seams • Cover tires with UV tire covers • Condition all rubber slide seals before retraction • Remove food, medications, valuables from RV
WINTER (Storage)	• Monthly trickle charger check on batteries • Inspect for pest entry monthly • Verify tire covers are secure after wind events • Run generator monthly (if accessible) - 30 minutes under load • Inspect roof cover for pooling water or damage • Check DampRid/moisture absorber levels - replace if saturated

CHAPTER 10 (CONTINUED)

Seasonal Calendar: Monthly & Weekly Tracking

Monthly Quick-Check Routine (All Year)

ITEM	DONE
Check battery voltage - charge if below 12.4V (storage) or 12.6V (active use)	■
Run generator under load for 30 minutes	■
Check tire pressure (even in storage - cold weather drops pressure)	■
Walk the roof - any new cracks or lifted sealant?	■
Check for pest entry signs - droppings, chewed wiring, or nesting material	■
Verify all valves are in correct storage position	■
Check DampRid or moisture absorber - replace if full	■

Service Interval Master Reference

INTERVAL	TASKS
Before every trip	Pre-trip inspection (Ch. 1), tire pressure, fluid levels, hitch check
Monthly	Battery check, generator exercise, tire pressure (storage), roof spot-check
Every 3 months	Slide lubrication, AC filter clean, tank sensor clean, solar panel clean
Every 6 months	Roof reseal, sidewall seam inspection, water heater flush, battery water check
Annually	Full engine service, brake fluid flush, seal all penetrations, tire date check
Every 2 years	Coolant replacement, brake fluid replacement, transmission fluid check
Every 3–5 years	Roof replacement inspection, tire replacement (age-based), battery replacement

★ **PRO TIP:** Keep a maintenance log in your RV - a simple notebook or phone note is fine. Recording what you did and when makes it easy to know what's due, and adds real value when you sell.

CHAPTER 11

Emergency Breakout Kit What Every RV Must Carry

When something goes wrong 60 miles from the nearest town at 10 PM, your emergency kit is the difference between a minor inconvenience and a nightmare. Most RVers carry a car emergency kit - but RVs have unique needs that a standard roadside kit doesn't cover. Here's exactly what to carry and why.

★ **PRO TIP:** Review and restock your emergency kit at the start of every season. Replace anything expired, depleted, or missing. A kit you haven't checked in two years may have dead batteries, dried sealant, and flat tire aerosol.

Roadside & Mechanical Emergency Supplies

ITEM	DONE
TPMS spare sensors and monitor - catch pressure loss before it becomes a blowout	■
Tire inflation kit / portable air compressor - 12V plug-in type rated for RV tires	■
Fix-a-Flat or tire plug/patch kit - for temporary repair of small punctures	■
Emergency triangles or LED road flares - 3 minimum, place 100–300 ft behind rig	■
High-visibility safety vest - wear when working roadside	■
Heavy-duty jumper cables or jump starter pack (lithium, 2000A minimum for motorhomes)	■
Tow strap rated at 2x your RV's gross weight	■
Extra 7-pin trailer connector and spare fuses for your fuse panel	■
Basic tool kit: adjustable wrench, pliers, screwdrivers, hex keys, zip ties	■
Duct tape and EternaBond tape - temporary seal for roof or body damage	■

Leveling & Campsite Emergency Items

ITEM	DONE
Wheel chocks - minimum 2, ideally 4 (never rely on jacks alone)	■
Leveling blocks (Lynx or similar) - stack to level on uneven terrain	■
Stabilizer jack pads - prevent jacks from sinking into soft ground	■
30-amp to 50-amp adapter and 50-amp to 30-amp dog bone adapter	■
Short extension cord (30-amp rated) for tight pedestals	■

Surge protector/EMS if not permanently installed in RV	■
Water pressure regulator and extra inline water filter	■
Sewer hose extension (10 ft) - some hookups are farther than you expect	■
Extra sewer hose ring seals - they wear out and cause drips at connections	■

CHAPTER 11 (CONTINUED)

Emergency Kit: Plumbing, Electrical & Safety Supplies

Plumbing & Water Emergency Supplies

ITEM	DONE
SharkBite push-fit fittings (1/2" and 3/8") - fix a burst pipe in minutes without tools or solder	■
Self-fusing silicone tape - wrap a leaking pipe for temporary repair	■
Extra Schraeder valve cores for tire stems	■
Small tube of plumber's putty and Teflon tape	■
Extra water pump fuse and water pump strainer screen	■
Portable water container (5-gallon) - for emergencies when hookup is unavailable	■
Extra non-toxic RV antifreeze (1 gallon) - for unexpected freeze events	■

Electrical Emergency Supplies

ITEM	DONE
Voltage tester / multimeter - verify campground power quality before plugging in	■
Spare fuses for all sizes in your RV's fuse panel - keep a fuse assortment kit	■
Wire connectors and electrical tape	■
Extra battery terminal clamps and battery terminal cleaner brush	■
Spare 30-amp fuse for shore power inlet	■
Headlamp with extra batteries - you'll need both hands working in dark compartments	■

Safety & Medical Emergency Supplies

ITEM	DONE
Fire extinguisher: ABC-rated, 2.5 lb minimum - one in kitchen, one in a cargo bay	■
Carbon monoxide detector with fresh battery - test monthly	■
Smoke detector - test monthly, replace battery annually	■
LP gas leak detector (electronic nose type) - detects leaks faster than sniff test	■
Comprehensive first aid kit with manual	■

Emergency contact card with insurance, roadside assistance, and family contacts	■
Copies of RV title, registration, and insurance - stored separately from originals	■
Flashlights (LED) with extra batteries stored in a dry bag	■
Emergency cash (\$200–\$300) - not all breakdown services take cards	■
Portable battery bank (power bank) - for phones when RV power is out	■

★ **PRO TIP:** Store your emergency kit in the same cargo bay every trip. When adrenaline is high, you don't want to search for the kit - you want muscle memory to take you right to it.

BONUS CHAPTER

Costly RV Mistakes First-Time Owners Make

Experience is a great teacher - but in the RV world, the tuition is expensive. These are the most common and most costly mistakes new RV owners make in their first year. Read them once, remember them always.

MISTAKE #1**Skipping the Roof Inspection**

Most new RV owners never walk their roof in the first season. By the time the ceiling stain appears, water has been traveling through the insulation for weeks. Inspect the roof within the first month of ownership and every 90 days after. Budget \$15 for a tube of lap sealant. The alternative is a \$15,000 wall replacement.

MISTAKE #2**Towing Over Capacity**

Your tow vehicle's maximum tow rating is not a suggestion - it's a structural and safety limit. Overloading stresses the hitch, frame, transmission, and brakes. It also voids your warranty and your insurance. Weigh your fully loaded rig at a CAT scale before your first trip. The cost is \$12. The alternative can be fatal.

MISTAKE #3**Using the Wrong Toilet Paper**

This sounds trivial. It isn't. Standard household TP doesn't dissolve in black tank conditions. It binds with waste, builds up around the sensors and dump valve, and eventually requires a tank pump-out that costs \$150-\$400. Use RV-safe TP or do the 30-second jar test before buying.

MISTAKE #4**Not Running the Generator**

New RV owners often avoid using the generator because it's loud and burns fuel. But a generator that sits unused for months will gum its carburetor, seize internal seals, and fail at the worst possible moment - usually when shore power goes out in a storm. Run it under load (with AC on) for 2 hours every month.

BONUS CHAPTER (CONTINUED)

More Costly Mistakes: Storage, Electrical & Buying Errors

MISTAKE #5**Storing Without Winterizing**

Skipping winterization because 'it probably won't freeze' is how RVers end up with \$8,000 in burst pipes in February. You don't need a deep freeze - even a single night at 28°F can crack pipes if water is sitting in the system. If there's any chance of freezing temperatures, winterize. No exceptions.

MISTAKE #6**Plugging In Without a Surge Protector**

Campground pedestals are notorious for miswiring, power surges, and low voltage - problems that destroy your inverter, converter, and appliances silently or in a spectacular surge. An EMS (Electrical Management System) unit costs \$150–\$350 and will pay for itself the first time it blocks a bad power event. Skipping it to 'save money' is how you spend \$2,000 replacing appliances.

MISTAKE #7**Leaving the Awning Out Unattended**

The #1 cause of awning damage is owner inattention - leaving the awning out while walking to the camp store and returning to find it shredded by a sudden gust. Always retract before leaving your site. A replacement awning fabric costs \$300–\$800. Replacement arms can add another \$400+.

MISTAKE #8**Skipping a Pre-Purchase Inspection**

Buying an RV without hiring an independent RV inspector is the single most expensive mistake new owners make. A professional inspection costs \$300–\$500 and takes 3–4 hours. It checks every system, every seal, every appliance - and can uncover \$10,000+ in hidden problems that the seller may not even know about. Never skip this step on any used RV purchase, regardless of how good it looks.

MISTAKE #9**Ignoring Tire Age**

Tires that look great and have deep tread can still be structurally compromised if they're over 6 years old. UV radiation breaks down the rubber internally - you literally cannot see the damage until it fails at highway speed. Check the DOT date code (4-digit stamp on sidewall). If tires are 6+ years old, replace them before your first long trip.

MISTAKE #10

DIY Repairs Beyond Your Skill Level

RV systems are interconnected. A gas line repair done incorrectly is a fire and explosion risk. An electrical repair done incorrectly can destroy your entire 12V system. Know your limits - there's no shame in calling a professional for gas, electrical, and structural repairs. The money you 'save' on a DIY repair can cost 10x as much to fix when it goes wrong.

★ **PRO TIP:** The best RV owners are the ones who stay curious. When something doesn't look or sound right, they investigate immediately - they don't wait for the next trip to check it out. In RVing, early attention is always cheaper than delayed reaction.

Thank You for Reading The RV OWNERS Maintenance Guide!

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